In the shadow of a great man

An autobiography by Paige Willowbranch

"I am the child of a child of a child of a very great man. A man who will outlive me and outlived every single person in my family."

"Where a fruit falls is not where it sets its seeds" - Kenlien Birch in *Traveling the tables of the coast*

Many of you will recognize my surname before anything else. I'd like to get this over with. I am the third generation from the great Thandil Willowbranch. Known for the Willowbranch publishing and scribing company, the world selling "Spikewreath" novels along with many many articles on the arcane, occult and the divine.

This has brought me no pleasure from the day of my birth, where my parents still trying to live up to their grandsires aspirations named me Paige, yes just like a page of a book. Well it's not **that** cruel it's also my maternal grandmothers middle name.

I've been groomed, pestered and in later years blackmailed into continuing our legacy. Oh, the horror to have a Willowbranch who doesn't write. This frustrates me to my very core, since to my own dismay I actually do like to write. Although to my parents and grandsires dismay I am frankly not that good at it.

Despite years and years of tutors, spiritual practices, arcane research and more activities to count I have nothing to write or say. Compared to my learned, travelled and prodigy of a grandsire I have not done anything yet, I've saved no maidens, I've slain no dragons.

"To soar is every bird's destiny" - Syf Silverwind in *Why winds cry*

Since this book will only be read and published post mortem, and the fact it evaporates into smoke after it leaves my person I have no fear to confess to this.

My mediocre success as an author is not even due to my own talent. If you are a fan of my work, I highly advice you to seek arcane health services. While scrounging around my grandsires libraries I found a pre calamity book, within hid a force I have not identified as of yet.

It has released any innate block I've experienced from learning druidic, arcane or divine magic though I am still an apprentice of each. In payment for this the entity seemed to have imbued my books with a low effective mimetic magic. This causes those with little connection to the world to obsess over the work and seek out more of it. Anyone with some sort of semblance of force of will seems to be unaffected.

"A man's measure is simple his height" - Dion Thunderbreaker in *Mountain Lords*

Very recently a man of great repute sailed north to chart and retake the lost continent of Farlorret. While my grandsire is particularly silent about the life before the calamities I intend to uncover them on my own.

My boat departs in three days, and I've pulled every copper from producing my previous books to fund this expedition. I will not return home before a discovery to overshadow my legacy has been unearthed.

As I arrived a well-dressed man greeted me at the guild. *Gustave Alleghieri*, a known name, the Guild master and a good contact. He accepted my recommendation though doubted by field experience and rudely suggested I ought to stay back to commit my self to filing reports.

I was then escorted to my room with a welcome gift of three health potions, I suppose that passes for health insurance out here. The room is not large, it contains a bed, a table with two chairs and an end table. I shudder to ask where a bath can be procured.

A few days have gone by, and no quests have been posted for someone of my new rank. "Too dangerous for someone unproven" they claim. I hate the idea of lounging, but I'll defer to my betters I suppose. In the meantime I've posted about my experience as a scholar for hire, even using my knowledge of publishing to produce high quality books and reports.

"Raised in the dark, safety in our mountain home" - Dew Windrose in *Tales of home*

I met a strange dwarf in the markets carrying a gigantic metal mirror up to a small chapel. About the size of the chapel to the Seldarine back at the estate but dedicated to the human aspect of Hanali, The Lady of Love Sune.

The dwarf introduced herself as *Kimmy, devout follower of Sune.* A fellow jack of all trades though in her case it seems to be limited to clerical duties. Her family seemed to have had differing expectation than her current ecclesiastical work. I surely can relate to that...

She was inclined to my plight that brought me here though I did not mention the source of my recent excellence. I ought to return her kindness once I've returned from my first expedition to tell her my exploits. Her kindness is something I've not felt in many years...

Gustave finally pulled through, acquiring a contract for a survey of the north-west plateau. I will use my somewhat adequate study of cartography I ought to be able to contribute well enough to earn my recognition.

I was paired up with a meek looking drow named "Nyx" and a utilitarian looking woman called "Foy". The propensity for adventurers to have single syllable names is beyond me.

The drow proclaimed himself a ranger, while leading us through every thorn bush this side of the continent and despite claiming he grew up in the mountains could not climb further than 20ft before falling. Ms Foy on the other hand turned out to be a much better climber and made light work of it.

After ascending the plateau we were met with the remains of a dwarf clutching a lockbox. Seeing the face of my first acquaintance since setting foot on the continent flash, I sought to give the body a proper burial. While trying to ascertain if any affiliation could be found on his person, A steel

pendant of dwarven cultural heritage. Inscribed on it was "So that you will never be away from home" with steel parts to symbolise home.

After a quick funeral service, we carried on. We sighted an earth elemental the size of a small house in the distant north, it was to our best guess rearranging the cliffs to suit as a nest.

Scouting further west before we were intercepted by starving Hyenas. The emaciated beasts did not hesitate to lunge even though we were armed. Mr Nyx was knocked out and almost dragged away if Ms Foy was not a moment faster than the reaper.

A better topographic map could be made from one of the mountain heights but the roving earth elementals and inadequate climbing gear made us retreat as for now.

During our last night on the plateau I was visited by what I can only assume is freshly spawned elementals in the form of swirling pebbles. I managed to sooth them with my magic and once dawn rose they vanished. A few of them into my backpack it turned out once we had declined rock walls again. I stashed these now dormant elementals in my inn room

He who lurks underneath the surface of pleasantries always stays the same - Masked stranger in *Cloaked Dagger: A winters bite*

Another quest with Mr Nyx. It seems we are destined to journey together, this time to find... blue camels. Gustave ensured me it was no jest, and I am inclined to believe him.

After arriving just east of town to find a caravan of blue people, with blue camels as advertised. Waiting for us was a tall, muscular woman with a strong wide nose and floppy ears on a bed of indigo curled hair. She wore armour polished to a shine and spoke with a cadence similar a circle matron. Her name is "Enira" and was our companion for the quest.

We conversed with the caravaners and their camels which led us over to a road. After walking along it scanning the edges for camel tracks leading off it, we met a merchant of a similar descent as the caravaners. He was selling pets and claimed to only help paying customers. With the lingering embers of the magic helping me to converse with the camels the pets being sold were screaming in a cacophony with one of them crying out "We were once people!".

While trying to disable the man's cart it bled and turned out to be a tame Mimic. After a bloody fight, where Mr Nyx once again was knocked unconscious, this time almost dragged away to be made into a pet instead of a meal. We brought the mimic to heel and the owner was slain by Mr Nyx, perhaps some sort of investment into seances would be useful.

We quickly found the run away camel being harrased by sentient plants close by. The plants were very complient with Ms Enira's exchange of purified water in exchange of letting the camel go.

We brought the camel back to caravan, leaving Enira to hold up her end of the bargain and the pets back to Embergate and Gustave ensured us that a solution would be looked into.

It digs and digs and digs and digs and digs... - Patient 034 in *The noice from beyond the room*

I've been misinformed about the lucrativity of Farlorret i fear. Gustave keeps perpetuating the notion that all the quests are out of my capabilities. It's been weeks since my last outing.

Others are reporting back to the guild on regular intervals yet nothing suited for me. Magical tombs, desecrated temples, I am sick of being made to stay back. This is not what i made my way all the way over the world for.

I've found a tip, I used the favour owed to me by Mr Nyx to tag along with his group to find some missing people, not something to put my name down in the legends but the pay is good and I'll be able to show the guild I'm able to do more.

His companions are a brute of a dwarf and a giant ant? I swear this man keeps strange company but I am in no place to complain.

The children were seen around the east part of Farlorret, with a killer on the loose to boot if you belive the rumours. Mr Nyx managed to scout the area and we ended up surrounding a small tent with several pairs of footsteps leading into it.

After some investigation the tent seems to hide an extra-dimensional space. Inside two children were playing tea party along with three stuffed dolls, two of which were tied to chairs with ropes.

THE INSECT TALKED TO MY MIND! I feel sick to my core, my psyche violated. I managed to compose myself enough to interrogate the children but I will need a bath to brush of the insect grime covering the inside of my skull.

Further in the tent a woman draped in embroidery and a theather mask skulks about in front of a wall of embroidery in the shape of a web.

She did not take kindly to our attempts to arrest her for kidnapping children so it came to blows. Once again Mr Nyx was knocked unconcious but avoided the clutches of death.

The woman seemed to excibit some sort of regenerative properties which seemed to intrest the dwarf, enough to protect her from my barrage of spells. I can't imagine what would be sufficiently interesting about it to warrent saving her life but it is not my problem nor my concern.

The bug kept up the psyhic throughout the fight against the woman, I'll need more than a bath. A whole body clense, maybe there is a spa in Embergate.

The rat won't outfox me again - The cat in *Natural*

Meetings up with a couple of monster hunters for the quest today. Fanatics of death more than protectors of peace and safety, just a flip side to paladins. Same rotten self justified coin.

Mr Nyx is joining today too, finally dropped the scimitars for some more practical blades, brandishing a Lolthian dagger, perhaps an heirloom.

We made out way out west, being side tracked Mr Nyx found it prude to stand in a throg of drakelings who insistently bite, breathed flames and exploded around him.

He did convince one to eat his savings at the bottoms of his backpack while we continued. We finally arrived at a camp of scouts and get our briefing. Seems the drakes in the surrounding area have gotten agitated and there has been sightings of tribes taming the drakes. The previous scouts returned hurt and Embergate can not afford to send more of their own forces out here.

We made our way down the cliffs and entered the affected area, we snuck up on the outpost and saw a gristly sight, a rat-beastfolk being chewed on by a drake to allow others to hold it down and try to pacify it. I was planning on going in trying diplomacy, but at the grisly sight we decided to launch an ambush to deal stop them from agitating the drakes.

After a fierce battle, we came out unscathed while the rat-kin lost about half their numbers. Their leader starting signing to us, luckily some of us understands the rudimentary signs. In what must've been through frustration of not understanding my mind mimicked the sensation the bug caused and reached out to the rat leader.

What I can only describe as standing in torrent of water I was blasted through the mind scape of the creature in front of me. Then it connected, thoughts becoming sentences transferring between each other. I was able to remind the rat kin of his position of possible execution if he did not comply.

We brought the creatures back to the outpost where the rangers were displeased. According to them diplomacy was their preferred method to deal with this tribe. Idealists are the same everywhere, I swear. Maybe a diplomat ought to have been dispatch instead of mercenaries risking their lives dealing with peer feeding rats. We got paid anyhow. Guess that's something.

On our way back one of the Monster hunters started to interrogate me for no reason, calling me a witch and demanded to tell her where my magicks came from. She was not satesfied with my display of my various exploits from different disciplines and demanded to know who I had gained the arts from. I reluctantly threw my grandsire under the cart, and it satesfied her averous need for my personal details. I hope she does not bother him and if she does, I hope she strictly leaves my name out of her mouth.

I swear upon my sword and honour to protect you with my life - Sir Gyllian in *Tales of the two peaks*

I convinced Mr Nyx into carving a focus out of a great piece of Lamannian Oak, and It turned out to be incredible. Thunderous bursts simply flow through the wood like it was nothing.

We ended up meeting with two new people. Mg Quinn & Lady Tukufu, both of which were quite charming and encouraged rather nice cooperations planned for the future.

Our mission was some possessed dolls being brought into Embergate causing quite a nuisance. It ended up being the cause of the Bug and Gnome who brought the Embroiderer back from our raid on her Tent.

We followed some soul swapped people into the sewers where the dolls had escaped to after stealing materials from a clothier. After going through them, sadly felling one of the people in the chaos we found the Embroiderer.

She was as cordial to being arrested as last time but this time we had a Lion and a surprisingly capable wizard which helped finally put an end to her reign of terror.

After our one-sided victory Lady Tukufu brought me and Mr Nyx a proposal. Employment. Or the most similar to it can become when working with adventurers under Farlorretian law.

The wound was profound, though no blade had touched his skin it still bled through every wince - Hilda in *Further still*

An ancient dwarven sewer system was found west towards the elemental plateau and its dangerous enough to send a whole squad out there to clear it out for development.

Me, Mr Nyx, a tiefling Ms Darrin and two faries, Ms Goodwind & Mr Enzo was the group Gustave collected. The trip there was uneventful since it's well travelled at this point.

Once we arrived the first floor was more or less cleared by the preliminary party apart from a lingering soul in search of their parents, and some carnivourus fungus.

We made our way down a level and had to deal with some insectoids who cleared out a seemingly ancient party of dwarven clerics or paladins who bodies we prayed for and reclaimed a flail.

Walking down to a third level we encountered pathways blocked off areas due to steam vents and in one such pathway we found a pair of giant crawling insects and mid combat we were ambushed by a grappling ooze.

We almost lost Ms Darrin to one of these creatures, her psyche showing her past wounds after we managed to save her by a hair's breadth. After spending all our energies we decided to move back and report the size of the expedition.

Fi, Fy, Fo, Fum - Atlas in *Atlas*

Mr Nyx appeared at my door in the worst state I've seen him in. He was holding onto his arm, covering a massive patch of scar tissue. I helped him in and he asked me to see if it was still possessed.

It turned out that he had be dismembered, his arm possessed, reattatched then unpossessed in that order. I looked him over, trying to restrain him with magic but it simply glanced off him. I worry he might be cursed or afflicted with something I am unable to identify. Or Worse. My grip on magicks is slipping...

After tearing through his armour to diagnose him I put in an order to have it repaired and enchanted as an apology. I also invited him to join me in the Bastion of Beauty for Ms Kimmy to have a look at him.

Not long after Lady Tukufu swung by, swindling a giant centipede egg onto me. For which I had to buy a terrarium taking up more than most of my appartment.

Then Maester Anchorstar asked of me to return to the dwarven sewers with Mr Nyx, Mr Farsset & Mr Nyx's roommate Issat. We managed to delve a further step deeper finding a massive automaton too big to even fight fairly.

All of my companions had death hovering above them but clung onto life by a hairs breadth. Below the colossus laid an opening into an underground town shorn in two from the ancient Farlorretian storms.

Negligence

I've not written in a few weeks. It is unlike me, but so are the circumstances I've found myself in. I will recount them to be best of my sleep-deprived mind's ability.

It started not long after Nyx darkened my door with his grievous wound. The monsters they had been fighting escaped and started terrorizing the populace. In normal fashion we tried to fight them off. They were stronger than any of us could've imagined.

Both me and Lady Tukufu fell, I was brought back by inducing a temporary vampiric strain into me and letting me feed on an ally. Lady Tukufu was not able to be healed. I was lucky to seal her soul temporarily within her corpse until a solution could be found.

So, for days I spent maintaining the barrier surrounding her body until she stood outside my door like she was not a corpse the day before. She explained others helped her soul return, and she wanted her story written down for the historical record, or as a way to process it all, or simply as an excuse for me to hear it.

With her return, the days are getting shorter and a mist is constant there are priests heralding some grand disaster, and we were tasked with finding relics to stave it off. I've grown quite fierce of combat, but I've never been more aware of my own mortality.

After this rather triumphant return, a lull in expeditions from the guild happened. So we found ourselves in merriment, me, Nyx & Mr Farssets younger brother drank and talked late into the night. Enoch Farsset, His illness is a harsh one. Unable to speak or sign without the help of his brothers magicks.

Well that's what we believed at least. I let down my guard with these two men. Nyx stopped treating me like his benefactor and Enoch treated me ... differently. Deep in our cups a paladin brust in, demanding the location of Silas claiming his many crimes. He was dissuaded by more sober parties, but Enoch ran home towards Silas with Lady Kimber.

On the way out she saw me in my state and magically sobered me up, a kind gesture was it not for the realization of every vulnerability I had shared with a man who could not see me as an equal unless on the brink of unconsciousness. I brought him home to sleep of his drinks, I dared not let him climb his treehouse.

This is where our falling out started. I confronted him with my disillusionment. The pressure of being infallible, resolute and alone was too much for me, in response he knelt down and said he did not understand, looking up at me for guidance. Nor do I think he ever will.

I left the apartment and found myself wandering Embergate, my magicks kicking in by themselves shrouding me in shadow. I met the Farsset brothers on the eve to my abode and followed them back to the library where I fell asleep in the younger brothers arms. A total stranger all things considered, but it was the only place I could turn to for comfort.

The following days, I spent in the library, scribing scrolls to keep my hands if not mind busy. Like all things, it too came to an end. Marlow, the guilds founder had died, and the guild was in great need for stability and resources. A squad was sent out to investigate an old gem mine on the upper plateau. The squad consisted of me, Mr Farsett, Enoch, Nyx, and a new face named Branimir.

Nyx looked like a hurt mutt whenever the handsome Branimir was by my side. It gave me pleasure to see him hurt after he had hurt me so. We made it to the mine, but raw positive energies was sporadically found inside. Mr Farsett tried to study it, but his condition made it impossible, and he was forced to explain it.

A demon was suffused with his soul which he kept under wraps, the positive energies he speculated could free him from it, but most likely burn him to a crisp. The pain from just being around it, caused him to falter and the demon to try to wrestle control. Meanwhile, Nyx threw himself into it, which healed his scars but also brought him to the edge of death. Where I stepped in and saved the idiot.

We returned to the guild with sparse jewels which paid for the expedition itself but barely.

After we returned, the following days a few noteworthy developments happened. Mr Farsset and Lady Tukufu began a romance, Lady Kimber got a threat by the goblin king to go to war with Embergate, and Nyx had returned to the inn to drink his sorrows away.

In the middle of the night, he returned to my home. Begging and pleading to be brought back. I of course had already surmised he would, and I will use that against him. He is a lost pup in need for discipline and a strong hand. If he needs a master that badly, I will fill that role.

After sending him away on some errands, to introduce the concept of menial labour in our new-found relationship. A better man stood on my doorstep. Enoch was here to 'spite' his brother. During his brothers sojourning with Lady Tukufu, he told the truth about Enoch's illness which he had gone to great lengths to hide beforehand.

In our mutual disillusionment we found each other in great company. The spell Enoch was under caused him to be unable to reveal himself, and he asked me to do it for him. To show me what his

brother so easily gave away. Underneath his crude mask was a face of pure alabaster, without skin, flesh or anything to make him human.

While having our minds linked that did not matter, he felt more human than anyone in Embergate.

Meanwhile, Mr Farsett had his conscience grow too weary to not tell Lady Tukufu about his demonic influence. With her previous experience with demon tainted men forcing themselves upon her family her rage was nothing but just. Causing such distress made Silas slip. His hold on his own body failed and the demon festering inside him broke loose.

The demon started burning the town until it released him and he and his brother was put in jail until further questioning had been done. Now I am sitting in my cold home with the one man who I deem an equal in jail for his brother's inability to communicate. I can see why my grandsire decided to not speak of this continent.

Physical description

Paige Willowbranch is a thirty-year-old woman of average height amongst humans and weighs in at approximately 100 lbs. Her elven heritage is diluted by 3 generations (She is therefore 1/8th moon elf) and therefore her fae traits are diminutive. A slight purple undertone to her pale skin along with a slight point to her ears are all that's left. She wears her wavy dark brown hair in a bob as a compromise between looking lady like enough for her family and easy enough to take care of for herself.

Her outfit is pristine from wear and consists of a high collared, cream coloured prairie blouse and a deep lilac vest. Both are accentuated by lace, the shirt along the edges and the vest on the panelling. She wears grey equestrian pants along with high, deep brown boots.

More often than not she is wielding a tome a smidge smaller than her upper torso which cover has a subtle texturing of closed eyelids and a curved staff made out of a deep oak with several baubles hanging from it.

She has an unexpecting pout-like snear behind her thinly brimmed round glasses made out of a thin jagged piece of amethyst, almost like she has stopped believing you'll ever say something worth her attention.

Some say when they look at her, the shadows being cast on her face from her hair dances and if you look for too long something within starts staring back